

GLOSSARY

A

ACID RAIN Most rain (and snow) is slightly acidic due to dissolved carbon dioxide. More strongly acidic rain results from atmospheric pollution or sometimes from gases released by volcanoes.

ACIDIFICATION Becoming more acid. The term is used especially in the context of the Earth's oceans and fresh waters.

ADAPTATION Any feature that helps an organism survive in its habitat or the process that allows it to do so.

ALGAE Any of a variety of plantlike life forms. They include single-celled species as well as larger forms such as seaweeds, and are especially important in the oceans.

ALTIPLANO The huge high-plateau region in the central Andes mountains of South America.

AMBUSH PREDATOR Any predator whose main feeding strategy is to stay in one place and wait for suitable prey to approach; also called a "sit-and-wait" predator.

AMPULLA (plural Ampullae) The enlarged end of a tube or duct.

ANTENNA (plural Antennae) The paired sensory "feeler" of insects, crustaceans, and some other invertebrates.

ANTLERS Paired bony structures, often branched, on the heads of most members of the deer family. Except for reindeer, only male deer have antlers. They are shed and regrown every year. See also *Horns*.

APEX PREDATOR A predator at the top of its food chain, hunted by no other animal (except humans).

ARACHNIDS The group of arthropods that includes spiders, scorpions, mites, and relatives. See also *Arthropods*.

ARCHIPELAGO A group of islands.

ARTHROPODS A major group of invertebrate animals having jointed legs and a hard outer skeleton. Arthropods include insects, crustaceans, and arachnids. See also *Exoskeleton*.

AXIL In plants, the upper angle between a leaf stalk and a stem, or between a side shoot and a main stem.

B

BACHELOR GROUP A group formed by immature males or males of the same species that have no sexual partners.

BILL The jaws of a bird, consisting of bone with a horny outer covering, also known as a beak. Also a similar structure in other animals, such as turtles.

BINOCULAR VISION The ability to see in 3D, which allows animals to judge distances.

BIODIVERSITY A general term for the variety of living things, either on the Earth as a whole, or in a particular region. Frequently it refers to the number of different species, but it can also be applied to genetic variety, ecological variety, and so on.

BIOMASS The total mass or weight of living organisms in a given area.

BIOME A large-scale ecosystem or set of ecosystems with characteristics determined by environmental factors, such as climate and geography. Deserts and tropical rainforests are examples of biomes.

BLOWHOLE The nostril(s) of cetaceans, situated on top of their heads.

BOG A mossy wetland, common in cooler regions, composed mainly of rotting plant material. It receives most of its water from rain and snow. Soils are nutrient-poor and acidic. See also *Fen*.

BOREAL Relating to or coming from the colder parts of the northern hemisphere, between the Arctic and temperate zones.

BOREAL FOREST The huge region of forest dominated by coniferous trees that circles the cooler regions of the northern hemisphere, between the tundra to the north and temperate broadleaved forests to the south. See also *Taiga*.

BRACKET FUNGUS Any of a variety of fungi that are relatives of toadstools and have spore-producing fruiting bodies that resemble shelves or brackets.

BROMELIAD A plant with numerous species, some of which grow in rainforests, using trees and shrubs for support. Typically they have rosettes of tough, waxy leaves in which rainwater collects. See also *Epiphyte*.

BROOD PARASITE An animal, such as the cuckoo, that makes use of other species to raise its young rather than raising its own young.

BRUMATION A state similar to hibernation that occurs in reptiles and other cold-blooded animals.

C

CAMOUFLAGE A means of being undetected used by predators, prey, and plants. It may involve color and/or pattern, shape, or even using a disguise. See also *Mimicry*.

CANID A member of the dog family, which includes foxes, wolves, and relatives.

CANINE (TOOTH) In mammals there is one canine tooth in each side of the upper and lower jaws. In carnivores it is enlarged and used for holding and/or stabbing prey.

CANOPY The part of the forest formed by the crowns of trees. It is also the name given to that part of a forest ecosystem.

CARAPACE A hard shield on the back of an animal's body—for example, in crabs and turtles.

CARNIVORE (1) A member of the Carnivora, the group of mammals that includes cats, dogs, bears, seals, and relatives. (2) Any flesh-eating animal.

CARRION Dead, decaying flesh.

CECUM A blind-ended part of the digestive tract, at the junction of the small and large intestines. See also *Hind-gut digestion*.

CETACEANS The group of mammals comprising whales, dolphins, and porpoises.

CHORDATE An animal that has a notochord, a rod support that runs the length of the body, for at least part of its life. See also *Notochord*.

CLASPERS In sharks and relatives, modified parts of the males' pelvic fins used to channel sperm to the female. In insects, claspers are structures used to hold the female during mating.

CLOVEN-HOOVED Having a hoof split into two halves, each containing one toe of the foot. This is a characteristic of two-toed herbivores, such as cattle and deer.

COALITION A cooperative alliance between individuals of the same species for defending or winning a territory or gaining access to females. Coalitions may be long or short term.

COLONY In zoology, any group of animals living together or in close association with one another, including birds such as emperor penguins in their breeding season; swarms of bees; and reef-forming coral polyps.

CONFLUENCE A place where two rivers, streams, or glaciers meet.

CONIFERS Predominantly evergreen trees and shrubs that produce seedbearing cones and have needle- or scalelike leaves. The most numerous of the nonflowering plants, including pines, firs, and spruces.

CORAL (1) Simple animals related to sea anemones and jellyfish. (2) The hard skeleton left behind by some coral polyps that can form large reefs.

CROP MILK A milklike substance rich in nutrients secreted by some birds in their lower throat (crop) and used to feed their nestlings.

CRUSTACEANS The dominant group of arthropods in the oceans, though they also live in fresh water and on land. Crustaceans include crabs, lobsters, shrimp, and krill. See also *Arthropods*, *Zooplankton*.

CURRENT A flow of water or air. In the oceans, large-scale currents exist on the surface and also at depth, driven either by the wind or by differences in temperature and salinity.

D

DECIDUOUS Trees and shrubs: having leaves that fall at a certain time of the year, such as winter or a dry season.